

Infrastructural Sedimentation in Scholarly Indexing

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We argue that bibliographic databases function less as neutral mirrors of a literature than as active participants in its constitution, selecting which venues become visible and which remain peripheral to the working researcher.

Our analysis proceeds in three movements. First we reconstruct the institutional history of indexing services. Second we examine how coverage decisions propagate into quantitative assessment. Third we consider the consequences for interdisciplinary fields.

Methodologically we combine archival research on editorial correspondence with a quantitative reconstruction of coverage expansion across four decades, treating the two evidentiary registers as mutually corrective rather than merely complementary.

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This improvisation has durable consequences. Once a venue enters an index it accumulates measurable citations, which in turn justify its continued inclusion, while excluded venues remain invisible to precisely the metrics that would warrant their addition.

We describe this dynamic as infrastructural sedimentation, borrowing the term from studies of standardisation, and we suggest it explains the striking stability of disciplinary hierarchies despite considerable turnover in research content.

The implications extend beyond bibliometrics. If evaluation regimes inherit the contingencies of mid-century commercial decisions, then reforms addressed only to the calculation of indicators leave the underlying selection mechanism untouched.

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